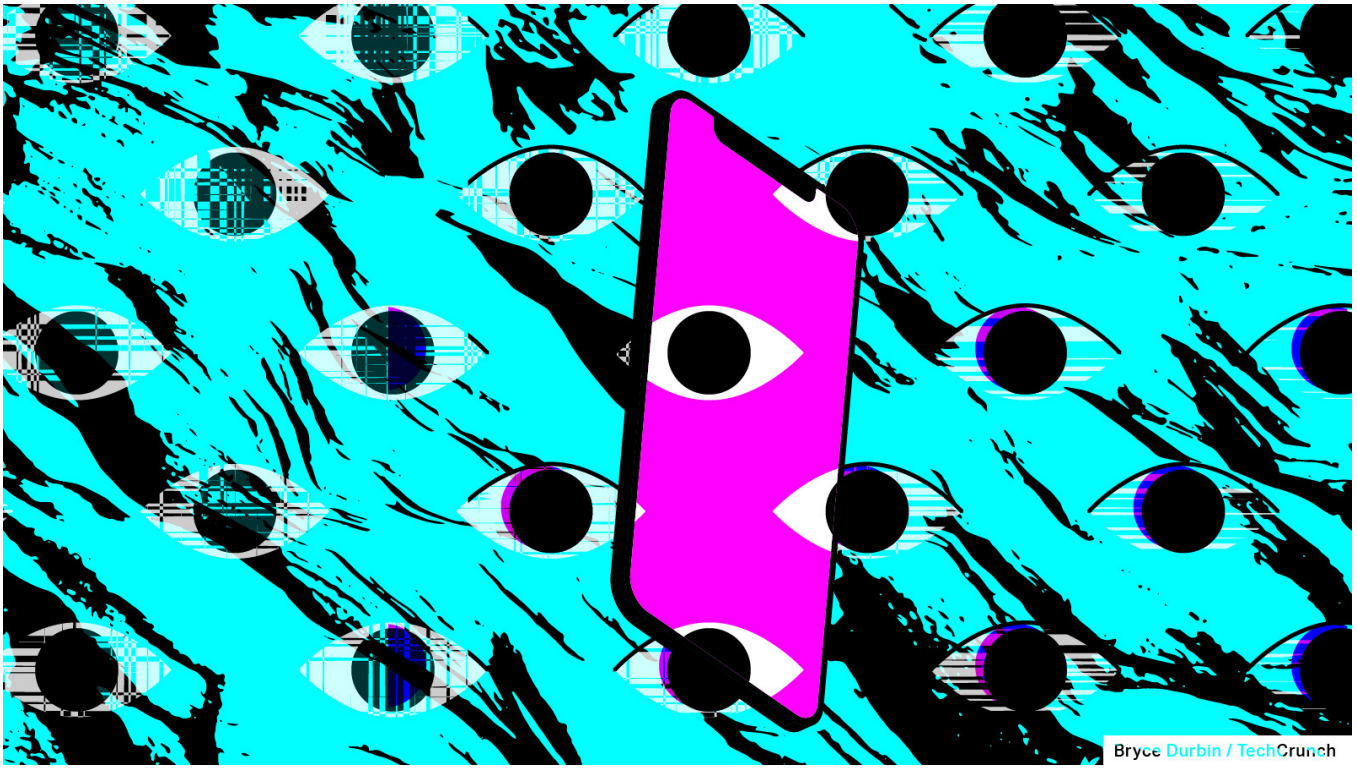
Russians caught stealing personal data from Ukrainians with new advanced iPhone hacking tools

techcrunch.com/2026/03/18/russians-caught-stealing-personal-data-from-ukrainians-with-new-advanced-iphone-hacking-tools

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai March 18, 2026



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A group of hackers suspected of working at least in part for the Russian government targeted iPhone users in Ukraine with a new set of hacking tools designed to steal their personal data, as well as potentially steal cryptocurrency, according to cybersecurity researchers.

Researchers at Google and security firms iVerify and Lookout analyzed new cyberattacks against Ukrainians which were launched by a group identified only as UNC6353. The researchers looked at compromised websites in a hacking campaign that, they say, is related to one uncovered earlier this month. This most recent campaign used a hacking toolkit the companies called Darksword.

The discovery of Darksword, which follows that of a similar hacking toolkit, suggests that advanced, stealthy, and powerful spyware for iPhones may not be as rare as previously thought. Even then, Darksword only targeted users in Ukraine, implying some restraint in what could have otherwise been a widescale hacking campaign targeting users worldwide.

In early March, Google revealed details of a sophisticated iPhone-hacking toolkit called Coruna. The search giant said that the tool was used first by a government customer of a surveillance tech vendor, then by Russian spies targeting Ukrainians, and finally Chinese

cybercriminals looking to steal cryptocurrency. As TechCrunch later revealed, the hacking toolkit was originally developed at U.S. defense contractor L3Harris, in particular by its hacking and surveillance tech department Trenchant.

Coruna was originally designed for use by Western governments, in particular those part of the so-called Five Eyes intelligence alliance, consisting of Australia, Canada, New Zealand, the United States, and the United Kingdom, according to former L3Harris employees with knowledge of the company's iPhone hacking tools.

Now, researchers said they uncovered a related campaign using more recent hacking tools exploiting different vulnerabilities.

The Darksword toolkit, according to the researchers, was built to steal personal information such as passwords; photos; WhatsApp, Telegram, and text messages; and browser history. Interestingly, Darksword was not designed for persistent surveillance, but rather to infect victims, steal information, and quickly disappear.

Contact Us

Do you have more information about Darksword, Coruna, or other government hacking and spyware tools? From a non-work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram, Keybase and Wire @lorenzofb, or by email.

Darksword's "dwell time on the device is likely in the range of minutes, depending on the amount of data it discovers and exfiltrates," Lookout researchers wrote.

For Rocky Cole, the co-founder of iVerify, the most likely explanation is that the hackers were interested in learning about the victims' pattern of life, which didn't require them to do constant surveillance, but rather a smash-and-grab operation.

Darksword was also designed to steal cryptocurrency from popular wallet apps, something that is unusual for a suspected government hacking group.

"This may indicate that this threat actor is financially motivated, or alternatively it may indicate that this (likely) Russian state-aligned activity has expanded into financial theft targeting mobile devices," Lookout wrote in its report.

But, Cole told TechCrunch, there is no evidence that the Russian hacking group actually cared about stealing crypto, only that the malware could have been used for that.

The malware was professionally developed to be modular and to make it easy to add new functionality, something that shows it was professionally designed, according to Lookout. Cole said he believes it's possible that the same person who sold Coruna to the Russian government hacking group also sold Darksword.

In terms of who was behind Darksword, for Cole "all signs point to the Russian government," while Lookout said it's the same group that used Coruna against Ukrainians, also a suspected Russian government group.

“UNC6353 is a well-funded and connected threat actor conducting attacks for financial gain and espionage in alignment with Russian intelligence requirements,” Justin Albrecht, principal security researcher at Lookout, told TechCrunch. “We believe that a case can be made that UNC6363 is potentially a Russian criminal proxy, given the dual goals of financial theft and intelligence collection.”

As for victims, Cole said that the malware was designed to infect anyone visiting certain Ukrainian websites, as long as they were visiting them from within Ukraine, so it wasn’t a particularly targeted campaign.

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The U.S. Justice Department accused Iran’s government of being behind the hacktivist group Handala, which last week claimed responsibility for the destructive cyberattack against the U.S. medical tech giant Stryker.

In a press release published on Thursday, the Justice Department said Iran’s Ministry of Intelligence and Security (MOIS) is operating Handala.

The Justice Department called the group a fake activist persona that the Iranian ministry used to carry out “psychological operations” against the regime’s enemies, to claim responsibility for cyberattacks, and to publish stolen information obtained during those hacks. The group also called for the killing of journalists, regime dissidents, and Israeli persons, per the DOJ.

The announcement came hours after the FBI seized two websites linked to Handala, as first reported by TechCrunch. The group used the websites to publicize its alleged cyberattacks, as well as to publish the personal information of dozens of people who allegedly worked for the Israeli military and defense contractors.

Handala took credit on its website for the March 11 cyberattack on Stryker, during which the hackers remotely wiped tens of thousands of employee devices. The hackers said the breach was in retaliation for a U.S. air strike on an Iranian school, which killed 168 children, according to Iranian officials.

FBI director Kash Patel was quoted in the DOJ's press release as saying that the FBI "took down four of their operation's pillars and we're not done."

Apart from the two websites used by Handala, the DOJ also seized two other domains allegedly used by Iran's MOIS via another hacktivist persona calling themselves "Justice Homeland" or "Homeland Justice." The DOJ accused Iranian government hackers of using those two domains to claim responsibility for hacking the Albanian government in 2022, in a cyberattack that resulted in government servers being taken offline and the theft of sensitive data. Microsoft also linked the attack against the Albanian government to the MOIS.

In an affidavit submitted in court to support the seizure of Handala's websites, the FBI said that Handala, Justice Homeland, and another hacktivist persona called Karma Below, "are part of the same conspiracy because they are operated by the same individuals."

Contact Us

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Handala responded to the DOJ's announcement in a statement posted on its official Telegram channel, where the hackers called the U.S. government actions "nothing more than the latest desperate attempts by the United States and its allies to silence the voice of Handala."

DomainTools' cybersecurity researcher Keith O'Neill told TechCrunch that Handala has already set up new domains that have not yet been seized.

The hacking group did not respond to a request for comment sent to a chat account publicized by the hackers, as well as an email address identified by the Justice Department in its affidavit.

A spokesperson for Iran's Permanent Mission to the United Nations did not respond to TechCrunch's request for comment. Stryker also did not respond to a request for comment.

Alex Orleans, the head of threat intelligence at Sublime Security who has tracked Iranian hackers for years, told TechCrunch that it is possible that the people behind the Handala persona are not the same individuals doing the actual hacking.

“Handala does not necessarily equate, one-to-one, with the actors conducting the activities it’s taking credit for,” said Orleans. “There could be multiple teams conducting actual intrusions while a distinct team is responsible for maintaining the persona — with all of these distinct elements coexisting within a larger unified MOIS element.”

“There’s a level of opacity there that can be difficult to penetrate,” he said.

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